BEGINNER PATH

AI Foundations & Everyday Productivity

From curiosity to confidence: learn to use AI tools safely and productively in 4 weeks, no experience needed.

Course Outline | Session Content | Lab Materials | Assessment

1. Course at a Glance

Item	Details
Duration	4 weeks, 5 days a week, 3 hours per day (60 contact hours) plus unlimited workspace time for practice
Level	Beginner. No coding, no prior AI experience
Class size	Ideal 15-25 learners, 1 lead trainer + 1 mentor
Format	About 25% demo, 65% hands-on labs, 10% discussion and sharing
Final result	A personal AI toolkit, 8 finished portfolio pieces, a custom AI assistant and a demo day presentation

Learning outcomes

- Explain in plain language what AI is, what it can and cannot do, and why it sometimes gets things wrong
- Write clear prompts using the R-T-C-F framework (Role, Task, Context, Format) and improve weak answers by iterating
- Use AI for writing, research, translation (English/Swahili), planning, studying and spreadsheets
- Create posters, social posts, CVs and simple business materials with AI and Canva
- Spot scams, deepfakes and misinformation, and protect personal and customer data
- Build a personal custom AI assistant and present a finished mini project

Who it is for and prerequisites

Students, job seekers, professionals, business owners, entrepreneurs, parents and seniors. Learners need only a smartphone or laptop, an email address and basic ability to type and browse. Day 1 includes a setup clinic for anyone who needs help creating accounts. Reading level: simple English with Swahili support; trainers should switch freely.

Tools and accounts (all have free tiers)

Tool	Used for
ChatGPT / Gemini / Claude	Main AI assistants for chat, writing and research (use the free tier of at least two to compare)
Google Docs, Sheets, Forms	Everyday documents and AI-assisted spreadsheets
Canva (Magic Studio)	Posters, social media graphics, CVs, presentations
Google Translate / AI translation	Swahili-English translation and checking
NotebookLM or similar	Summarizing and questioning documents and notes
WhatsApp Business	Catalog, quick replies and AI-written messages for small business

Daily session format (3 hours)

Time	Block	What happens
0:00-0:20	Warm-up	Recap, 'show one thing you tried since yesterday', quick quiz
0:20-1:05	Concept + live demo	Instructor demonstrates on the projector; learners follow along
1:05-2:35	Hands-on lab	Individual or pair work on the day's lab, instructor circulates
2:35-3:00	Share-out + homework	2-3 learners demo; exit ticket; next-day challenge

Instructor tip: keep demos under 20 minutes at a time. Learners should have their hands on keyboards for at least 60% of every session. Pair beginners with stronger learners (peer teaching) and keep an 'AI wins' board on the wall.

2. Four-Week Outline

Week	Theme	Weekly deliverable
Week 1	Meet AI: Foundations and First Prompts	Personal AI toolkit page and prompt notebook
Week 2	AI for Everyday Productivity	Study/work plan, research summary and productivity workflow
Week 3	Create and Earn: Content, Design and Small Business	Portfolio of 5 designed pieces (poster, social set, CV, product listing, short video script)
Week 4	Apply: Build Your Own AI Assistant and Demo Day	Custom AI assistant, mini project, portfolio and demo day presentation

Week 1: Meet AI: Foundations and First Prompts

Goal: Remove fear, understand how AI works at a high level, set up tools, and write good prompts.

Day 1: What is AI? Setup clinic

Concepts:

- AI in daily life: M-Pesa fraud checks, maps, spam filters, voice assistants
- Generative AI as a very well-read assistant that predicts words (not a search engine or a person)
- Strengths and limits: speed and drafts versus mistakes and made-up facts

Hands-on lab: Create accounts, run the same question on 2 assistants, compare. 'AI or Not?' game with 10 mixed examples.

Homework / challenge: Ask AI 3 questions about your own life or work; write what was useful and what was wrong.

Day 2: The R-T-C-F prompt framework

Concepts:

- Role, Task, Context, Format with before/after examples
- Specific beats vague: audience, tone, length, examples
- Iterating: 'make it shorter', 'explain like I'm 12', 'give 3 options'

Hands-on lab: Prompt Makeover relay: teams improve 6 weak prompts and vote on the best output.

Homework / challenge: Build 5 reusable prompts for your own work in the prompt notebook.

Day 3: Safe and responsible AI

Concepts:

- Privacy: what never to paste (ID numbers, passwords, M-Pesa PINs, client data)
- Hallucinations and how to fact-check in 3 steps
- Scams, voice cloning, deepfakes and fake job offers, with Kenyan examples
- Bias, fairness and honesty about using AI help

Hands-on lab: Fact-check lab: find and fix 5 mistakes planted in AI answers. Deepfake spotting exercise.

Homework / challenge: Write your own 'Safe AI Rules' list (7 rules) and share with a family member.

Day 4: AI as your writing partner

Concepts:

- Emails, letters, reports and messages in the right tone
- Editing and proofreading versus writing from scratch
- Keeping your own voice: give AI a sample of your writing

Hands-on lab: Write a formal request, a friendly follow-up and a complaint letter; rewrite in 3 tones each.

Homework / challenge: Draft a real message you need to send this week and send it.

Day 5: Lab day: Personal AI Toolkit

Concepts:

- Choosing the right tool for the right job
- Organising prompts, saving chats, naming conventions

Hands-on lab: Build a one-page toolkit: your top 3 tools, 10 saved prompts, your safe-use rules. Peer review in pairs.

Homework / challenge: Prepare 60-second 'What AI did for me this week' talk.

Week 2: AI for Everyday Productivity

Goal: Use AI to research, summarize, plan, learn and work faster in real life.

Day 6: Research and summarizing

Concepts:

- Asking better research questions; follow-up questioning
- Summarizing long text, articles and documents
- Checking sources and finding original references

Hands-on lab: Summarize 3 documents (news article, policy page, product manual) into a 1-page brief with sources checked.

Homework / challenge: Research a decision you face (course, loan, device) and write a pros and cons brief.

Day 7: Translation and language

Concepts:

- English, Swahili and Sheng awareness: where AI does well and poorly
- Translating forms, notices and customer messages
- Practicing languages with AI conversation partner

Hands-on lab: Translate and back-translate 5 texts; mark errors; build a bilingual customer message pack.

Homework / challenge: Have a 10-minute practice conversation in a language you are learning.

Day 8: AI for learning and study

Concepts:

- Personal tutor prompts: explain, quiz me, test me
- Study plans, flashcards and revision summaries
- Using AI honestly in school and work

Hands-on lab: Pick any topic (KCSE subject, a trade, a certification). Generate plan, flashcards and a 10-question quiz; take it.

Homework / challenge: Follow your study plan for 3 days and track results.

Day 9: Spreadsheets and documents with AI

Concepts:

- Google Sheets: formulas, cleaning data, simple charts with AI help
- Meeting notes to action lists
- Templates: budgets, schedules, invoices

Hands-on lab: Build a household or small business budget sheet with AI-generated formulas and a chart. Create an invoice template.

Homework / challenge: Track real spending for 3 days in your sheet.

Day 10: Lab day: Plan Your Life Project

Concepts:

- Combining tools into one workflow
- Time saving audit: what tasks to hand to AI

Hands-on lab: Build a weekly planner, task list and reminder routine using AI. Time-audit 5 tasks before and after.

Homework / challenge: Prepare a 2-minute demo of your workflow.

Week 3: Create and Earn: Content, Design and Small Business

Goal: Make professional content and business materials and discover simple ways to earn.

Day 11: AI image and design basics

Concepts:

- Writing image prompts: subject, style, light, mood
- Canva Magic Studio: design, background removal, resizing
- Copyright, branding and ethical image use

Hands-on lab: Design an event poster and a social media square for a real or imaginary Ruiru business.

Homework / challenge: Redesign a flyer you have seen locally and compare.

Day 12: Social media content

Concepts:

- Content ideas, captions, hashtags and posting calendars
- Short video scripts and reels outlines
- Writing in English and Swahili for local audiences

Hands-on lab: Create a 2-week content calendar plus 6 finished posts for one business.

Homework / challenge: Post 3 pieces for a real page (yours or a friend's).

Day 13: CVs, cover letters and job search

Concepts:

- Tailoring a CV to a job advert
- LinkedIn profile and elevator pitch
- Interview practice with AI as the interviewer

Hands-on lab: Produce a tailored CV, cover letter and run a 10-question mock interview, recorded in notes.

Homework / challenge: Apply to one real opportunity using your new CV.

Day 14: AI for small business

Concepts:

- Product descriptions, WhatsApp Business catalog and quick replies
- Customer replies, price lists and simple marketing plans
- Simple market research and competitor checks

Hands-on lab: Set up a WhatsApp Business catalog draft with 5 products, auto-reply and a promotion message.

Homework / challenge: Test your promotion message with 5 real contacts.

Day 15: Lab day: Build a Business-in-a-Box

Concepts:

- Putting branding, content and customer messages together
- Pricing and costing a basic service

Hands-on lab: Create a complete starter pack for a business idea: name, logo concept, poster, 5 posts, price list, customer messages.

Homework / challenge: Pitch practice: 90 seconds.

Week 4: Apply: Build Your Own AI Assistant and Demo Day

Goal: Customize an AI assistant, complete a real project and present with confidence.

Day 16: Your custom AI assistant

Concepts:

- Custom instructions, Projects, GPTs or Gems: what they are
- Writing system instructions: purpose, tone, rules, examples
- Uploading knowledge files; testing and improving

Hands-on lab: Build an assistant for a real need (study buddy, shop helper, church or community notice writer, job coach).

Homework / challenge: Collect 5 test conversations and note improvements.

Day 17: Mini project sprint 1: plan and build

Concepts:

- Choose a problem from your life or community
- Project canvas: user, problem, AI help, success measure

Hands-on lab: Write the project canvas and build the first version with mentor check-ins every 30 minutes.

Homework / challenge: Gather feedback from one real user.

Day 18: Mini project sprint 2: improve and test

Concepts:

- User feedback and revising
- Quality checklist: accuracy, tone, safety, usefulness

Hands-on lab: Test with 3 classmates, improve, and complete the quality checklist.

Homework / challenge: Prepare slides or a demo script.

Day 19: Portfolio and next steps

Concepts:

- Building a simple portfolio folder or Canva site
- Writing 'what I can do with AI' for CV and LinkedIn
- Learning paths: moving to Intermediate

Hands-on lab: Assemble portfolio: best 8 pieces with a short description each. Peer feedback round.

Homework / challenge: Rehearse your demo.

Day 20: Demo Day and graduation

Concepts:

- 3-minute demos, live Q and A, peer and trainer feedback
- Certificates and community commitments

Hands-on lab: Present to the class and invited guests (families, local business owners). Complete reflection and feedback form.

Homework / challenge: Share your project and keep learning in the workspace.

3. Learner Materials Pack

Print these for every learner and keep digital copies in the shared drive. Instructors can copy and adapt freely.

A. Starter Prompt Library

#	Use	Prompt (replace the brackets)
1	Explain simply	Act as a patient teacher. Explain [topic] to a complete beginner using an example from daily life in Kenya. Keep it under 150 words.
2	Email	Write a polite email to [person/role] about [situation]. My goal is [goal]. Tone: professional and friendly. Under 120 words.
3	Summary	Summarize the text below in 5 bullet points, then list 3 questions I should ask next. [paste text]
4	Study	Create a 7-day study plan for [subject] for someone with [time] per day. End each day with a 5 question quiz.
5	Translate	Translate this into natural Swahili for [audience]. Then give me an English back-translation so I can check it.
6	Business post	You are a social media helper for a [type] business in [place]. Write 3 short captions with emojis and a call to action. Product: [product].
7	Interview	Be my interviewer for the job of [role]. Ask one question at a time, wait for my answer, then give feedback and a score out of 10.
8	Decision helper	I must choose between [A] and [B]. Ask me 5 questions first, then give pros, cons and a recommendation with reasons.
9	Fact check	List the claims in this text that need checking and suggest where I can verify each one. [paste text]
10	Improve	Improve my text below. Keep my voice. Fix grammar, make it clearer, and tell me what you changed. [paste text]

B. R-T-C-F Cheat Sheet

Letter	Meaning	Example
R	Role: who AI should act as	You are a career coach
T	Task: what to do	Review my CV and suggest 5 improvements
C	Context: facts, audience, limits	I am a fresh graduate applying for a bank teller job in Thika
F	Format: how to answer	A table with 'Problem' and 'Fix' columns

C. Safe AI Checklist

- Never share passwords, PINs, ID numbers or other people's private details
- Verify names, dates, numbers and laws before using them
- Do not trust urgent voice notes or videos asking for money: call back on a known number
- Tell people when AI helped you with important work
- Keep final responsibility: you approve everything you send

D. Weekly Reflection Sheet

- Three things I built this week
- One thing AI got wrong and how I caught it
- One task I will now do faster with AI
- One question I still have

E. Trainer Resources

- Slide decks per day (10-15 slides, mostly screenshots and demos)

- Offline backup: printed examples in case internet is slow; phone hotspot plan
- Attendance and progress tracker; 'AI wins' board photos; certificate template
- Accessibility: large-font handouts and seat near screen for seniors; patient pairing

4. Capstone Project

Each learner completes one real mini project that solves a problem in their own life, work or community and demonstrates at least 4 skills from the course.

Example project ideas

- A study assistant for KCSE subjects with quizzes
- A job-search kit with tailored CV, cover letter and interview coach
- A small-shop marketing pack with posters, catalog and WhatsApp replies
- A church, school or community communications assistant
- A parent's helper for homework, meal plans and family budgets

Submission checklist

- Project canvas (1 page)
- Working AI assistant or finished content set
- 3 test results and improvements made
- 3-minute demo and short reflection

5. Assessment and Certification

Component	Weight	What we look for
Attendance and participation	20%	Present, engaged, helping others
Weekly labs	30%	Completed and shared, quality of effort
Prompting skill	15%	Clear prompts, good iteration
Safe and responsible use	10%	Fact checking and privacy habits shown
Capstone and demo	25%	Useful, working, well presented

Certificate of Completion: 80% attendance and a completed capstone. Certificate with Distinction: 85% overall score and an outstanding demo.